

A Packing of 21 Four-Spaces in $\mathbb{R}^{13}$

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Abstract

We give 21 4-dimensional subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^{13}$ whose smallest squared chordal distance is at least 2.907254. This cell of the table of best Grassmannian packings has no published value. The best value implied by known packings is 2.900631, obtained by deleting 1 of the 22 four-spaces of the packing found by this search. The value is checked with exact rational arithmetic from integer coordinates. We do not claim it is optimal.

1 Result

Theorem. *There are 21 subspaces of dimension 4 in $\mathbb{R}^{13}$ whose pairwise squared chordal distances $D(a, b) = 4 - \text{tr}(P_a P_b)$ are all at least*

$$D_{\min} = 2.907254 \dots$$

The exact value of $D_{\min}$, a rational number, is given in Appendix A.

2 Context

N. J. A. Sloane's *Table of Best Grassmannian Packings* (last modified 1997), now maintained by Henry Cohn, lists values for some N in the row $m = 13$, $n = 4$. The cell $N = 21$ is blank in Sloane's table, in Sloane's coordinate files and in Cohn's table as checked on October 8, 2026. The best value implied by known packings is 2.900631, obtained by deleting 1 of the 22 four-spaces of the packing found by this search. The Rankin simplex bound for this cell is $4(13 - 4)/13 \cdot 21/20 = 2.907692$, and the value above lies below it.

3 Verification

Each subspace is given by an integer $m \times n$ basis Y (coordinates times 10^{12} , rounded). With $G = Y^\top Y$ the projection is $P = YG^{-1}Y^\top$, so for two subspaces

$$\text{tr}(P_a P_b) = \frac{\text{tr}(\text{adj}(G_a) A \text{adj}(G_b) A^\top)}{\det G_a \det G_b}, \quad A = Y_a^\top Y_b,$$

an exact rational number. No orthonormality is assumed and no floating point is used. Run

`python grassmann/verify.py grassmann/packings/m13n4N21.txt`

in <https://github.com/Ge-limin/math>.

*Found and checked by Claude, a model released by Anthropic, running on the author's laptop. The author sent the prompts.

4 How it was found

Many random starts of gradient descent on the Grassmannian against a log-sum-exp of the pairwise overlaps, sharpened over time, then a polishing stage (`grassmann/solve.py`); about 67 seconds on one laptop, with about ten such searches running at once.

A Exact value

numerator:

```
67297547563371241768389720562296754531623640684528096300373162211380467
986236793083397067417737212682861598132084005265216293376636092711900565
2405557892186810972152743778798201301647241979
```

denominator:

```
231481481481630855326035153842883934546494149472179627594773381440063912
886684537965705248210279395756816598125479717001017835503344165053548435
5674317793992270356763492563345914200428406473
```

B Coordinates

21 blocks of 13 rows with 4 integers each; divide by 10^{12} . File: `grassmann/packings/m13n4N21.txt`.

```
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